OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Youth Advisory Committee Failed to Reach Quorum, Council Admits Model Isn't Working

Sent 13 August 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 3 September 2026

To: Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer, Shoalhaven City Council

To: Councillors associated with the Youth Advisory Committee

Dear Mr Constance and Councillors,

I have spent some time reading the agendas and minutes of Shoalhaven City Council's Youth Advisory Committee.

There is a problem here.

In fact, Council has already acknowledged it.

The report prepared for the committee's meeting on 29 July 2026 says:

"Council staff acknowledged that the current YAC model is not meeting the needs of young people..."

That is not my assessment.

It is Council's.

What happened next rather dramatically demonstrated the problem.

The Youth Advisory Committee requires six members for a quorum.

On 29 July, two voting members turned up.

Caycee Sutton and Chloe Turner were the only voting members recorded as present.

The meeting couldn't proceed.

The official minutes record:

"The meeting did not reach the required Quorum and lapsed."
(Source: Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Minutes, 29 July 2026, p. 1.)

Those present instead conducted the planned workshop informally.

I am therefore asking the CEO and the councillors involved with this committee a fairly simple question:

What are you going to do about it?

This committee has an important job

The Youth Advisory Committee isn't supposed to exist simply so Council can say it has a youth committee.

Its stated purpose is to:

"represent the interests and views of young people to Council and the Community."
Its role includes allowing young people to discuss issues affecting them, make representations to organisations and governments, gain experience in local government and community affairs, and address youth issues themselves.

Importantly, the committee can make recommendations to Council.

(Source: Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Agenda, 29 July 2026, pp. ii–iii.)

Those are worthwhile objectives.

But there is a considerable difference between having objectives written into terms of reference and demonstrating that they are being achieved.

Young people have been telling you what matters

The minutes show that young people who have participated haven't been short of things to say.

At the February meeting they identified issues including:

mental health;

cost of living;

affordable housing;

homelessness;

safe spaces for young people;

climate change and the environment;

violence, safety and crime;

inadequate public transport;

substance use; and

difficulty accessing employment.

(Source: Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Minutes, 26 February 2026, pp. 2–3.)

These are substantial issues.

Young people told the committee that mental-health services were difficult to access.

They spoke about lengthy waiting lists.

They described difficulties getting around the Shoalhaven because of inadequate public transport.

They talked about housing, employment and financial pressure.

So I would like to know what happened next.

Not what was discussed.
Not what was "noted".
Not what was "considered".
What actually happened?

Show us the outcomes

I would ask Council to identify the tangible outcomes produced by the Youth Advisory Committee over the past two years.

How many recommendations has it made to Council?
How many were adopted?
How many resulted in an identifiable change?
How many matters raised by young people were referred to another level of government or organisation?
What happened to those referrals?
What has changed for young people because this committee exists?
If there are substantial achievements that aren't obvious from the minutes, I would genuinely like Council to identify them.
They deserve to be reported.
But if they can't be identified, that tells us something important too.

Two people turning up should be a warning

A committee requiring six voting members couldn't assemble six.

It got two.

That shouldn't be dismissed as an unfortunate meeting.

Council should be asking why.

Were young people properly notified?
Is the meeting format wrong?
Is meeting at the Council administration building appropriate?
Are meetings too formal?
Are they held at the wrong time?

Are young people being asked to participate without seeing anything happen afterwards?
Is the committee representative of young people across the whole Shoalhaven?
Are councillors sufficiently involved?
Do participants believe the committee actually influences Council decisions?
Or has the committee simply ceased to be a useful way of engaging young people?
These are questions Council should be able to answer.

Council is already redesigning it

Council has engaged a Youth Empowerment Project Officer on a six-month contract to undertake a co-design process and identify a youth-led approach to ongoing engagement.

(Source: Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Agenda, 29 July 2026, YA26.11, p. 11.)

That may be exactly what is required.

But replacing one process with another isn't necessarily reform.

There needs to be a measure of success.

Otherwise Council can run workshops, conduct surveys, hold consultations and produce reports indefinitely without knowing whether anything has actually improved.

So before the six-month project gets too far down the road, I would like to know what success will look like.

My questions to the CEO and councillors

Could you please answer the following questions publicly:

How many Youth Advisory Committee meetings have been scheduled during the past two years?

How many achieved the required quorum?

How many voting youth representatives are currently appointed, compared with the number of available positions?

Why does Council believe only two voting members attended on 29 July?

What action has Council taken during the past two years to recruit and retain young people on the committee?

How many formal recommendations has the committee made to Council during the past two years?

How many of those recommendations were adopted or resulted in identifiable action?

What are the five most significant tangible outcomes Council can identify as having resulted from the committee's work during that period?

What happened after young people raised mental health, housing, cost of living, transport, homelessness, employment and safety concerns?

Were any of those matters formally referred to Council officers, the elected Council, NSW Government agencies, MPs or other organisations?

If so, what happened?

How does Council currently report back to young people and tell them what happened after they provided their views?

What does Council believe has caused the deterioration in participation that culminated in the failure to achieve quorum on 29 July?

What are the CEO and councillors associated with this committee now going to do to address that problem?

What is the total cost of the six-month Youth Empowerment Project Officer engagement?

What measurable objectives have been established for that project?

How many young people does Council expect the redesigned engagement model to reach?

How will Council measure whether those young people are geographically and socially representative of the Shoalhaven?

When will the results of the six-month project be reported publicly?

Will Council commit to publicly reporting, at least annually, what young people told Council, what Council agreed to do and what was actually delivered?

And one particularly important question

There is a question in Council's own July workshop that deserves to be turned back on Council.

Young people were asked:

"What should happen after young people give their input? How to close the feedback loop."
(Source: Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Minutes, 29 July 2026, p. 1.)

Exactly.

Council should answer it.

Because asking young people what they think isn't youth engagement if their contribution disappears into minutes, reports and another round of consultation.

Young people need to be able to see the connection between participation and action.

Sometimes Council won't be able to do what they ask.

Sometimes the issue will belong to the State or Commonwealth Government.

Sometimes an idea won't be affordable or practical.

That's fine.

Tell them.

Explain why.

Advocate elsewhere where appropriate.

But close the loop.

Councillors have a role in this

The July minutes record no councillor as attending the meeting. Apologies were recorded from Cr Karlee Dunn and Cr Debbie Killian.

(Source: Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Minutes, 29 July 2026, p. 1.)

I don't suggest that councillors are responsible for young people not attending.

But elected representatives do have some responsibility for demonstrating that participation in local government matters.

If young people are being encouraged to spend their time talking to Council, there should be a reasonable expectation that councillors are interested in what they have to say.

That is particularly important when the committee exists partly to give young people experience in local government and community affairs.

This should be fixable

I don't raise this to argue that Council should abandon youth engagement.

Quite the opposite.

The issues young people have raised demonstrate why effective engagement matters.

The present situation should be treated as an opportunity to rebuild the system around what young people actually need rather than preserving a committee simply because Council has traditionally had one.

Perhaps that means a different committee.

Perhaps it means meetings in schools.

Perhaps it means local groups in Ulladulla, Nowra, the Bay and Basin and other parts of the city.

Perhaps it means digital participation.

Perhaps it means young people joining Council project teams for matters directly affecting them.

Perhaps it means something entirely different.

That is precisely what the co-design process should determine.

But whatever replaces or reforms the current model needs one thing the present documents don't demonstrate particularly well:

outcomes.

Council has already acknowledged that the current Youth Advisory Committee model isn't meeting young people's needs.

The next scheduled meeting then failed to achieve quorum.

There were two voting members in the room.

The warning lights are flashing.

The question for the CEO and councillors is no longer whether there is a problem.

Council's own documents have answered that.

The question is:

What are you going to do to fix it?

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero
Eye on Shoalhaven Council

Sources

Shoalhaven City Council, Youth Advisory Committee Meeting Agenda, 29 July 2026.

Shoalhaven City Council, Minutes of the Youth Advisory Committee, 29 July 2026.

Shoalhaven City Council, Minutes of the Youth Advisory Committee, 5 May 2026.

Shoalhaven City Council, Minutes of the Youth Advisory Committee, 26 February 2026.